

A letter to first-year students, from a nearly graduated one

Here's what I wish I knew when I was new



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Dear first-year students,

You might have a concept of what you want your time at SFU to look like, or maybe you have no idea. Maybe you have friends by your side, or a sibling who's shown you the ropes. Or maybe you're completely new to the country, and know no one, in which case, my younger self probably would relate to you most. Maybe you're lost in the Robert C. Brown Hall and you stumbled upon our newsstand, desperate for some words of encouragement (good luck). Wherever you are, I hope to impart some of the lessons I've learned as you navigate new waters.

As the eldest child, I never had anyone whose footsteps could lead me into adulthood, no one to walk through spiderwebs in my path. So, in January 2019, after half a gap year to settle in Vancouver, I braved a tough façade as I entered campus for the first time. Riddled with anxiety but trying to seem cool and collected, I felt like I was navigating a fog (at times, I literally was). Maybe you can relate, or perhaps you're calculating how many years I've been here, thinking, "Why would I take advice from someone who took this long to graduate?" Well, four years might be a perfect timeline for some people, but learning isn't a race. I know that sounds like something your kindergarten teacher told you after reading *The Tortoise and the Hare*, but it's true!

It took me a while to accept that four courses in a semester would never be manageable for me. Actually, two courses a semester is my ideal course load. There were many times when the readings and assignments were so interesting, but it felt impossible to absorb the material and put in the effort required on top of the week-to-week deadlines of multiple courses, work, and personal life. Finding shortcuts becomes an unspoken expectation in classrooms; skimming, cramming, and now that ChatGPT is in the picture, it's easier than ever for students to bypass intentional, deep work and studying. But what good is a degree, and the expenses and time that come with it, without learning and enjoying the experience?

The value of a degree and the job market can change. Of course, it's good to set long-term goals, but make sure the joy and satisfaction of learning is one of them. Be prepared to revisit and change your goals with time. I used to say I "wasted my time" trying to pursue an English and publishing minor during my earlier years. However, just because I decided not to go forward with either of those options, doesn't mean the courses I took weren't valuable. I read and discussed literature that has inspired me as a writer. I also designed, printed, and bound a book all on my own (PUB 131) that I now proudly display on my shelf, and I had fun!

Engaging in learning also increases neuroplasticity in the brain, which strengthens things like memory, critical thinking, and resilience as you get older. Don't underestimate the process of taking notes during lectures, for example, rather than scrolling away and thinking you can reference the slides later. I highly recommend COGS 110 if you want to learn how to study and learn effectively. I still remember most of what I learned because we used physical flashcards that we practiced with every week. The same goes for BPK110 (Human Nutrition), because I applied the same approach to studying and saw that I was able to be disciplined. These are just some of the interesting electives to choose from in your journey of self discovery!

If you have a full schedule this semester, don't worry. Usually first-year courses are more manageable, and this is your time to find out what works for you. I also realize being able to take my time and limit courseload has been a luxury. There are all kinds of pressures that may prevent this, from parents, scholarships, and even internal pressure to follow a timeline you set. But do not feel pressured by comparison.

This was something I struggled with. I would see others juggling four to five courses, multiple extracurriculars, making the honour roll, seemingly balancing it all, and think I wasn't as capable as them. Academic achievements are

worth celebrating, but don't forget everyone is facing unique obstacles and circumstances that we don't often see or celebrate. I, for one, never had the privilege of not having to work full time to pay rent and afford food (and of course my little daily \$7–8 beverages). If I didn't have to work, then maybe I could've balanced a lot more academically. There are so many factors that affect someone's experience – language barriers, disability, even something like having to commute to campus versus living in residence, can take hours off of one's day that would've been spent studying. Comparing yourself to others is futile, and leaves you feeling inadequate.

Making friends was never easy for me, and it took me a few years to start making lasting connections. Though I am from Vancouver, my family moved around overseas for the second half of my life. You'd think this would make me adaptable, but social anxiety and self doubt have always lingered. I was technically not an international student, but also couldn't really relate to the ones who grew up here. It didn't help that someone laughed at my answer to a professor's question after courageously raising my hand in lecture (don't laugh at people!) If I had been less guarded during those early years, and realized I wasn't alone in feeling alone, I would have had a much easier time. Know that you are not alone, and people are more focused on themselves anyway. Letting go of caring about what others think isn't easy, but it comes with experience.

I'd get intimidated by a tutorial room where you can hear a pin drop, everyone swiping through their homescreens, avoiding eye contact. Being the first person to say, "Hi, how do you guys feel about this course?" is so easy, and it can really clear cold air. Ask someone when they're on campus and if they'd like to meet up or study after class. I'd also recommend moving around the classrooms and lecture halls to sit next to and gain familiarity with different people. This isn't assigned seating and you won't offend anyone by moving seats! (Was I just the biggest overthinker?) Some people will just be class friends, who you'll never see or hear from again, and that's OK. Although, I would highly recommend exchanging numbers rather than social media to start, unless you want to finish your degree with a bunch of ghosts in the Instagram panopticon (can you tell I'm a communication student?).

I met one of my best friends during quarantine in an online class, who we ended up connecting by just talking over Zoom and eventually meeting up. I also met a lot of people in clubs and working at *The Peak*. That's another reason why I took my time to graduate – I got practical work experience doing co-op, and working for the student paper. I learned so many skills that I'm not only graduating with a degree, but multiple work experiences in the field I want to pursue. There are tons of ways to get involved and meet people. Go to welcome day, attend an event, get involved outside of courses.

A few final tips: ask for extensions! Even if your professor says no, there's no harm in asking. Don't be too intimidated by your profs and TAs either, as they are usually approachable (unless they aren't – don't take it personally). The Burnaby Mountain, and Vancouver in general, can be gloomy, so make sure you prioritize connection with others, vitamin D, and take care of yourself. Also, meet and get curious about people who have different experiences and backgrounds from you. There are international students here from all over the world who may not know anyone here, and their lived experiences are unique – not branching out from a closed, familiar circle is boring and a missed opportunity.

As I enter my final semester (fingers crossed), I'm grateful I was able to take the time to grow into the person I wanted to be when I graduated. I feel confident in myself, well educated, and I have fully explored the different avenues available to me to figure out what I wanted. The most exciting part of being a first-year student is the endless possibilities – you get to make the experience yours. So as you enter this next chapter, know that you won't have it all figured out on day one, but if you trust the process and dim your light out of fear of being judged, you'll be just fine.

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